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# THE GREAT INDIAN POLITICAL CHURNING

**The decade proved to be ostrich-like. It saw old verities vanish and new ones raise their heads, as Congress hegemony ended and religious fundamentalism began.**

**T**he 1980s fundamentally altered India's political landscape and also planted the seeds of an economic revolution. This ostrich-like decade saw the old verities vanish and new ones raise their heads, some quite unwholesome and others hugely promising. Two political developments of the decade stood out for their long-run significance: the end of Congress hegemony in politics and the emergence of, what Amartya Sen has called, "illusion of singular identity", which meant the obsessive identification of human beings with their religious selves.

Looking back, the disappearance of Congress hegemony was a great surprise. It was a decade of resounding victories for the Congress party right until the very end. In January 1981, Indira Gandhi triumphantly returned to power, a mere three and a half years after she had been thrown out in a stunning twist of electoral fate, conjured up by her Emergency excesses. Her assassination in October 1984 gave Rajiv Gandhi an unparalleled victory too. Even under Jawaharlal Nehru, the Congress party was never able to win three-fourth of the Lok Sabha seats.

Yet, in 1989, Rajiv was decisively voted out. It is clear that the strengthening of new anti-Congress forces was only temporarily postponed by Mrs Gandhi's assassination, which gave an extraordinary spike to Rajiv's electoral fortunes for five years. The next decade-and-a-half witnessed two alternative political formations: the Hindu nationalists in the north and west and the lower caste politicians dominant in the south for decades, finally forcing their way up in the north as well. No one in the 1980s could have predicted that the Congress would poll less than 10 per cent of the popular vote in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, as it does these days. The 1989 elections inaugurated the new

electoral era, as the BJP and the lower caste parties began to eat into the social base of the once mighty Congress.

But a more significant development was the attempted religious simplification of India's multidimensional self. A religious construction of Indian identity was vigorously promoted in politics and an effort was made to subsume all other identities, which Indians traditionally had, under an all-consuming religious framing of politics. With this massive simplification arose terror as a mode of quotidian politics. Concurrently, solid conditions for the rise of Hindu nationalism were also created.

Indian terrorism was born in Punjab, a most unlikely site, for it was the centre of the Green Revolution, the nation's richest state in the 1980s and an established supplier of legendary fighters to India's armed forces and also a state with a history of good relations between Sikhs and Hindus. That Sikhs had or developed irresolvable political grievances against Delhi, or against the Hindus, was shocking. Sikh integration in mainstream India was always considered deep and exemplary. How could the Sikhs possibly rebel against Delhi? How could that come about?

Political analysts have a rare consensus on what caused the unfortunate developments in Punjab. In an interconnected set of events, Mrs Gandhi's use of a Sikh preacher, Sant Bhindranwale, to weaken her electoral adversaries—the ruling Akali Dal—morphed into religious terror on the part of some Sikh religious organisations and counter-terrorism operations on the part of the Indian state. It was her monumental blunder to meddle in Sikh religious politics, for which she, of course, paid with her life when her Sikh bodyguards, seeking revenge, killed her for desecrating their holiest shrine—the Golden Temple. The systemic im-